

1720–1770

MANTUAS AND OPEN ROBES

Throughout most of the 18th century the basic style of women's dress was the open robe, a garment that was put on rather like a modern-day coat. A separate skirt known as a petticoat was worn beneath, and the gap at the bodice covered by a stiffened panel called a stomacher, which was pinned in place to the robe by a series of tabs. The robings (foldback edges of the gown) covered the pin heads. Fashion for the most formal occasions was set at the French court of King Louis XV and copied throughout Europe, particularly the style known as *le grand habit* – a heavily boned bodice, and a separate, richly decorated skirt and train. The mantua, a style of dress that involved folding and draping the sides and the back panel, was also popular and seen at the English courts of the Hanoverian kings.



Rococo robe The undulating lines of the design on this dress silk are characteristic of the mid-18th-century rococo movement in the decorative arts. The robe falls in softer, less formal folds than the exaggerated lines of the heavily hooped dresses.



Open robe This 1738 open robe of lustrous brocaded silk is worn with a separate petticoat over a circular hoop made of cane or whalebone. The robe is open down to the waist over a triangular stomacher decorated with a single bow.

SHOES

For most of the 18th century women's shoes were made of fabric. Although the material might be patterned dress silk, it was not usual to choose a gown and shoes in matching material. Sometimes separate leather overshoes were worn to protect the fabric shoes. A metal buckle decorated with cut-glass pastes was pinned into the latchets (side straps) to fasten the shoes.



Tip-up, pointed-toe shoe



Lower heel in 1740s



Latchets or straps flap across the vamp (top) of shoe

